



Claimed Early, Cooked Late

Timestamping a Street Potluck’s Capped Sign-Up Sheet Against When Each Household Actually Decided What to Bring

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Motivation

Institutions are known to lock in a commitment well before the scoping that should justify it. Does an ordinary street roster do the same — does claiming a sign-up slot early mean the claimant has already decided what to bring, or only that they got to the sheet first?

Research questions

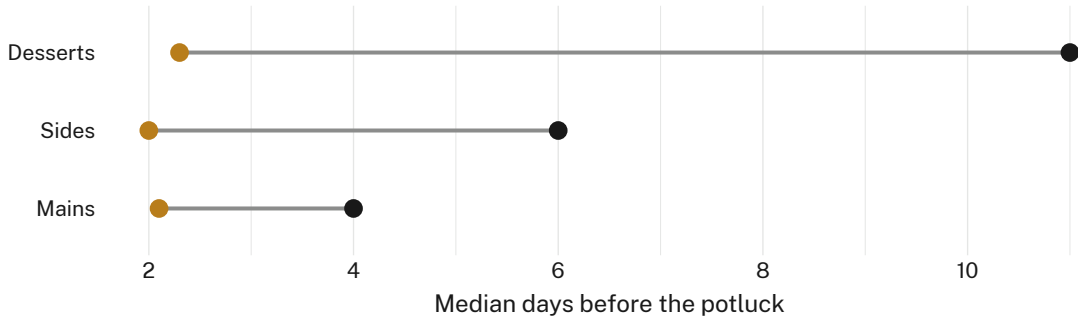
- Timestamp each category-slot claim against the same household’s confirmed dish
- Compare the claim-to-confirmation lag across mains, sides, and the capped dessert category
- Test whether an early claim predicts a firmer, less-revised final dish

Approach

- 9 streets · 11 monthly cycles · 214 household sign-ups; shared paper sheet, dessert quota fixed at 4 per cycle throughout
- Claim timestamp from the sheet; confirmation timestamp from each household’s “what I’m bringing” message to the street group chat
- Revision flagged when the plated dish differed from the confirmed one; quota held constant as a covariate

What we found

Dessert slots are claimed a median 11 days before the potluck, against 6 for sides and 4 for mains. The confirmed dish itself lands a median 2 days out regardless of category, and claiming early does not lower the rate at which the confirmed dish is later revised.



Median days before the potluck: the dessert quota pulls sign-ups eleven days earlier, but the confirmed dish lands within a day of mains and sides across all nine streets (n = 214, March-June 2026).

Interpretation

A capped category filters who holds a seat at the table long before it settles what lands on it. The quota manages the roster, not the meal: 21% of confirmed dessert dishes are later revised, statistically indistinguishable from the 19% revision rate for mains and sides claimed a week closer to the event. Next: instrumenting a workplace morning-tea sign-up sheet, where the mug-washing roster shows an early-claim, late-decision split of its own.

Selected references

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We thank the coordinators of the nine monitored streets for sign-up-sheet and group-chat access; no identifying information retained beyond a street code.

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“A slot claimed in week one. A dish decided the night before.”

Dessert sign-ups land 11 days earlier across nine streets; the recipe still doesn’t.